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Tarakihi decision puts industry ahead of national interest

22 September 2026

The Minister of Oceans and Fisheries, Hon Shane Jones, today released his decision on the management of tarakihi stocks.

As previously highlighted by EDS, the eastern stock is estimated to be just **7.7% of its unfished biomass**, while the western stock is healthier at an estimated **29%**, but is **in rapid decline**.

Fisheries New Zealand (FNZ) put forward three options to reduce harvest of these threatened stocks. For the **eastern stock** the options were a reduction of 39% (option 1), 58% (option 2) or 78% (option 3).

EDS sought a total closure, until the stocks recover. Seafood New Zealand and other commercial fishing interests sought a 20% reduction. The Minister has adopted the industry's proposal of 20%.

For the **western stock**, the three options put forward by FNZ were a reduction of 55% (option 1), 69% (option 2) and 84% (option 3). The Minister has adopted the smallest reduction of 55%.

"Given how depleted tarakihi stocks are, and how important this fish is for New Zealanders, the Minister's decision is extremely disappointing," said EDS Policy Director Raewyn Peart.

"EDS called for a complete closure of the fishery given its perilous state. But the Minister's decision doesn't even mention closure as an option. This is despite the eastern stock being below the hard limit, which is when closure needs to be considered under the Harvest Strategy Standard.

"Instead, the Minister has by-passed FNZ's proposals for the eastern stock, and implemented the one put forward by industry, which is less than half the reduction proposed in FNZ's most lenient option.

"FNZ's analysis indicates that the harvest reductions adopted by the Minister will mean the stocks will continue to be overfished.

"It is also clear the western stock will continue to decline and the eastern stock will remain at very low biomass levels for an extended period. This brings the risk that any adverse event, such as a marine heatwave, could tip it over the edge so it never recovers.

"The Minister acknowledges his decision carries "greater residual sustainability risk, including a longer period at low biomass".

"EDS is now investigating legal options to challenge the decision.

"Given the high level of uncertainty around recruitment, productivity and the impacts of climate change, the Minister's decision does not appear to be sufficiently precautionary as required by the Fisheries Act.

"The Minister's decision also fails to protect any nursery habitat or juvenile aggregation areas as proposed by FNZ and supported by EDS. This is despite the Fisheries Act's requirement to protect habitat of particular significance for fisheries management.

"The Minister appears to have been swayed by the interests of the seafood industry rather than protecting the overall interests of the country in ensuring a sustainable population of New Zealand's most commonly sold fish species.

"The decision also highlights the need to urgently reform the fisheries management system. EDS is calling for an independent inquiry into the fisheries management system to be established in the first 100 days of the next government," Ms Peart said.

Find the Minister's decision [here](#)

Find the EDS tarakihi submission [here](#).

+64 9 302 2972
manager@eds.org.nz



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